

It's not often that a film director will truly welcome the input of another creator on their work, but then it's not often that the creator in question is one of the two men responsible for revolutionising UK comics and supplying the US with some of their best writers. John Wagner joined *2000 AD* in the very early stages, and created the anthology comic's longest running strip: *Judge Dredd*.

Set 100 years in the future and progressing in real time (meaning the character is now over 70, kept in peak condition by future technology and sheer determination), *Dredd* helped set the tone for a new, grittier time in comics; a biting commentary on the various political situations of the era. Wagner, born in the US but brought up as a proud Scot, is charming, friendly, blackly humoured and very to the point. Hints of Dredd, then, but without the bastard parts…



"THE MORE I SEE THE PEOPLE AT THE TOP OF SOCIETY, THE MORE I WANT TO RESIGN FROM THIS WORLD"
JOHN WAGNER

You had some quibbles about the new *Dredd* film during its production, but does the final cut get the Wagner seal of approval?
I'm right behind it. My problems stemmed, I guess, from never having seen a film in production. I didn't know they could do so much with it between the rough cut and final version. It's like the difference between seeing an artist's rough pencils and the final inked and coloured art. I admit I was worried when I went up to see it the last time – if I wasn't happy with it I couldn't give it my support, and I knew that would hurt it. This time it picked me up and carried me right along with it, and I'm thinking "Yeah, go!" I was so relieved. The people at DNA aren't like our idea of the breed. They're honest and straightforward and they put a lot of hard work into getting things right, in this case into making sure Dredd *was* Dredd. I wanted them to succeed.

Alex Garland and Karl Urban are both big fans. Does this shine through in the film?
One of the good things about working with Alex was that he understood Dredd, so I wasn't always fighting to keep him true to character. Karl – sometimes his resemblance to my image of Dredd is uncanny. If there's to be a follow up I hope he will be available.

The 1995 Stallone film was visually astonishing, but didn't have much in common with the tone of the *Judge Dredd* comics. Is the new film different in that respect, and does the low budget actually help a little in that regard?
I don't know if the budget helped, but it didn't particularly harm it. They could have thrown another $100 million at it and it might have looked a bit flashier, but it wouldn't have altered the core of the story, which is pretty much pure *Dredd* – lean and mean.

Alex Garland was very open to your feedback, including cutting a kiss scene between Dredd and Judge Anderson. Has it been a good experience helping your character appear on screen?
Yes, it has been very enjoyable. For a start they offered me a little respect, which didn't happen on either of the other two films I've been involved with. I don't think [David] Cronenberg even knew that *A History Of Violence* came from [John Wagner and Vincent Locke's 1997] graphic novel till near the end of filming. Alex can be pretty hard to shift at times – naturally, a writer has to believe in his work – but still, he was more than willing to listen, and on a lot of matters I had to accept that he knew the film business and I didn't. He understood what was possible and what would work. For my own part, I'm not that precious about my work. If they've got to change things, so be it, just don't lose what's good about it. That's why I hated the Stallone *Dredd* and liked *A History Of Violence* – they at least didn't rip the heart out of the story.

Olivia Thirlby's portrayal of Judge Anderson and Lena Headey's villain may well see more female fans picking up *2000 AD* titles. Anderson is your creation, and one of the few strong women in comics who are not defined by romance or men – was this deliberate?
Absolutely. I don't mind romance in stories, but I don't need the message hammered home, so when things get too lovey-dovey my finger heads for the fast forward button. Sex, I would only use where it was an integral part of the story, for instance in 'America' or the DeMarco story. I don't know about Anderson's romantic life and, for the moment anyway, I don't want to know. It would demean her to give it too much weight.

You've described Judge Dredd in the past as "a heartless hero for Thatcher's heartless new Britain." Is he as relevant today as he was back then?